SUBMISSION TO THE JOINT STANDING COMMITTEE ON ELECTORAL MATTERS

[redacted]

[redacted] CANDIDATE IN THE FEDERAL ELECTORATE OF FORREST

Overarching thoughts

Australia is fortunate to have compulsory voting, preferential voting and an independent authority in the Australian Electoral Commission(AEC). The AEC must continue to be resourced appropriately to hire adequate staff, train those members of staff and manage the election process. The reduction in numbers of Electoral Offices significantly impacts regional candidates. To place my nomination I had a 420km round trip to Perth. My scrutineers had to travel 150 -300 km per day to Canningvale in Metropolitan Perth to oversee the counting of the votes. I am fortunate to live in one of the cities closest to Perth but this would be a significant barrier for candidates in even bigger electorates such as Durack or O'Connor.

Personal experiences:

I was a Candidate in the Federal Electorate of Forrest at the last Federal Election held May 3, 2025. I wish to outline my experiences as a candidate who in the final weeks of the campaign was exposed to lies, misinformation and out right hostility inspired by the [redacted] Party and their affiliate groups, Teals revealed and Keep the Sheep. I would like to raise my concerns about the ongoing use of how to Vote cards. I would also like to lodge a formal complaint about the involvement of members of the Christian Brethren and their active campaigning for the [redacted] party in the Electorate of Forrest.

Whilst I acknowledge that the behaviour of the [redacted] party and affiliates was within the laws as they relate to Electoral advertising, I feel it is time to revisit these laws particularly in the context of the rise of AI and social media.

Media and community manipulation and misinformation Campaign

[redacted]

[redacted]

The [redacted] party produced a number of letters (see example pictured above) that were distributed by Australia Post that contained gross misrepresentations of my positions (statements 6, 7 & 9) and

background (statements 8 & 10). They also misrepresented the previous actions of members of my campaign team (statement 5) and made statements that had no relevance to me or my history, but conflated my association as a [redacted] to presume how I would vote if elected (statements 3, 4 and 10)

This second pamphlet referenced an article produced by the West Australian which contained lies and mistruths about my campaign which we corrected in our local press. The West Australian refused to acknowledge any errors or reprint any comments supplied by myself to correct the record. However the [redacted] Party reproduced this article in another mailout continuing the lies about my donors and transparency and how I would vote if elected. Sky News and [redacted] also used information from the article first published in the West Australian to raise unsubstantiated claims about my donations and associations on National television .

[redacted]

The [redacted] Party and their affiliates also produced TV advertisements along the same lines as the above pamphlets, reproducing the same misinformation and lies as facts.

This third pamphlet is another example of the type of imagery and information that was delivered again by Australia Post to each letter box.

These pamphlets were duly authorised and therefore within the bounds of our current Electoral Laws.

Suggested actions:

It is time for our Electoral laws to be revised so that this tabloid style of smear campaign is no longer permitted. The candidate who is the target has no effective means of combating this misinformation and even when attempts are genuinely made to fact check, the newspapers do not publish an update or retraction unless threatened with legal action. Once it is on the internet or in letterboxes , there is no means of providing truthful counterinformation.

It could be as simple a statement as “Parties and candidates are to produce electoral information only as it directly pertains to their policies and candidate.” This limits the need to define misinformation or

disinformation but forces the candidates to focus only on their campaign and not uses resources to the detriment of another.

Third party groups, such as Advance, or Keep the Sheep must be registered with the AEC and should not be allowed to publish or promote election material during the election campaign. They should not be allowed to have signs at the polling booths.

Polling station behaviour

This next photo shows the prepolling station in Bunbury and the corflutes produced by [redacted] Party affiliates Keep the Sheep, and Teals Revealed. The Keep the Sheep campaign is not a registered political party but had an authorisation on their information and so we were unable to raise a complaint. The corflutes were prominently displayed at each polling booth across the electorate. The Keep the Sheep group also had a pamphlet to be handed out by supporters that contained many factual errors and misinformation about my position on the live sheep trade and its planned closure. Unfortunately I do not have a copy of this pamphlet in my files.

The Teals Revealed campaign was an attempt to smear my campaign with a supposed history of voting behaviour, but as I had never been elected previously, this information could not be held to be relevant to my campaign. It was used widely however to attack and discredit me. It also contained factual errors about voting records of independents but was used as authorised material at every polling booth.

This barrage of negative information and imagery at the polling booths with questionable authorisations needs to be controlled. When combined with loud sometimes aggressive tactics from supporters of all parties, each trying to hand over polling information, it is an extremely threatening and toxic environment for a voter to enter.

It is a questionable use of finite resources with large number of corflutes and bunting aimed at taking up the maximum real estate for your candidate or party, around the polling booth.

When a voter arrives to vote, they should not have to run the gauntlet or be confronted by unpleasant images or lies.

Suggestions:

All information at a polling booth must be authorised by the candidate directly and should only be allowed to reference their position or policy.

Limits to the numbers of volunteers should be enforced.

Limits to the numbers of signs banners corflutes should be enforced.

Social media

The targeted attacks by the [redacted] Party, Keep the Sheep and Teals Revealed led to an online wave of vitriol, on my social media. Many comments were misogynistic, hatefilled and aimed at discrediting my reputation and credibility.

The following are examples of posts that were circulated without authorisation and with the use of AI:

This is the original type of post that was released by my campaign and authorised.

2025 Federal Budget

The government says this budget will help.

But in Forrest, we're still waiting for the things that matter.

Here's what they promised — and what I'll fight for instead.

[redacted]

[redacted]

The following posts were produced by a community group and published and shared widely, with no authorisation or acknowledgement of the use of AI

Vote [redacted] last, with [redacted] and the [redacted] ⚠️

No Wind Turbines - Scott River · Join

No Wind Turbines - Scott River · 2 May · 🌍

Vote [redacted] last, with [redacted] and the Greens ⚠️

[redacted]

MEDIA STATEMENT

[redacted] **supports:**

Taxing Inheritances
Ending Oil & Gas FIFO jobs
Geographe Bay Wind Turbines
The [redacted] & Communism
Another VOICE Referendum
Destroying Sheep Farming
Banning Utes & 4WD's
Swearing at other candidates

1 2 comments

Like Comment Share

The Climate 200 backed candidate for FORREST [redacted] has announced she will advocate for Wind Energy in the electorate ⚠️... See more

Unfortunately the toxic and misogynistic behaviour then spilled over into reality where I was shouted at and verbally abused at polling booths, volunteers were verbally abused and my partner was spat at whilst manning a polling booth in Harvey on Election day.

Our society is becoming more polarised and social media is creating environments where hate speech and untruths are no longer moderated by the platforms. Statements can be re-written or reproduced by AI or Bots and distributed to hundreds of thousands of people within seconds every day. Our algorithm feeds us more of the same and worse ,instead of balancing information.

As a candidate it is impossible to know who is writing the comments and whether they live in Forrest or Fiji. As the owner of the space, it is important to keep the commentary respectful but blocking individuals who breach the rules, seems to raise a particular hatred and inspires that person to continue to post even more vitriolic and offensive claims on other pages. These are completely unmoderated most times and allow the most vile commentary to be perpetuated and spread.

The general public appears to still believe that what is said during an election campaign is true, as we do not have truth in political advertising laws.

Why would anyone wish to become a political candidate if they can be slandered, misrepresented, defamed and subjected to hatred, just for wanting to be a representative for their community?

Why would anyone want to volunteer to support a candidate or campaign when they run the risk of such antisocial behaviour?

We need to rapidly address this situation to continue active participation in our democracy by a wide variety of people.

Since the campaign ended, I have uploaded several images as complaints to the AEC regarding lack of authorisation but I have received no confirmation of receipt nor notification of action. There needs to be an accountable rapid response from the AEC to complaints.

Suggestions:

Using AI to alter any aspect of a candidate (image voice video) should be a criminal offence punishable by Federal law with significant penalties

Consideration should be given to implementing a ban on political advertising on social media during an election period. If this is not possible, then an agreement should be entered into that the social media companies are obliged to provide balance in their algorithm, during the election period, so that one advert from eg the [redacted] party is automatically followed by an advert from each other candidate.

Posts on social media should be appropriately authorised, preferably by the candidate.

Posts from third party groups or social media pages like those shown above must list a contact person and suitable contact details and be subject to AEC oversight

How to Vote cards , Corflutes and volunteer numbers at polling booths.

How to vote cards are now simply a waste of money and resources and should be banned.

With the advent of many popular online tools such as Build a Ballot, the vast majority of people presenting to a polling booth no longer use how to vote cards.

The general public still believe that preferences belong to the candidate or the party and this is perpetuated by the major parties handing out How to Vote cards with preferences filled in.

The [redacted] Party did not accurately reflect the ballot paper, with a listing of names only, not the associated political party or independent status.

With the rise of [redacted], many of whom choose to not allocate preferences on the how to vote card, this is a source of confusion for the public and again an easy way for the major parties to undermine the [redacted] candidate.

The experience of “running the gauntlet” to enter the polling booth and place your vote was clearly very confronting for many voters. In combination with the use of volunteers such as the Christian Brethren who aggressively shouted slogans and harassed electors, these hostile and intimidatory practices must stop. There should be a maximum number of volunteers at any polling booth, a simple display of how to vote cards , affixed to the fence of the polling booth.

There should be a limit on the number and type of corflutes permitted., and clear rules on who is authorising the material and how to contact them.

Suggestion:

If How to vote cards are to continue the Government should run an education campaign ahead of the next election about preferential voting and to whom preferences actually belong.

Voting accessibility postal voting and prepolling.

On many occasions I witnessed older less able voters struggling to access polling places.

With the delay in the election, it seemed that many voting centres in Forrest were less than ideal, with the Sea Scouts Centre in Bunbury a particular case in point. The polling place had a road within 1-2 metres of the entry with both through traffic and people coming to vote. On some days the line breached the road before the AEC intervened. The disabled parking bays were very few in number and required the disabled person to then cross the road to enter the centre. There were insufficient AEC staff to monitor these bays and assist voters who wished to vote in their cars. The lengthy queues also made it very difficult for physically impaired voters as again there were insufficient AEC staff to assist with moving them along the line. Volunteers from all teams would often try to facilitate a process and then be accused of approaching a voter unacceptably or breaching the rules by wearing a campaign Tshirt too close to the entry.

A number of voters approached me wishing to obtain a postal vote. Unfortunately they were unable to achieve this due to the delays

between voter nomination, drawing of the ballot position and the AEC publication of postal voting matter. The time lines for the nominations and ballot need to be brought forward to give both the AEC time to complete preparation of postal voting papers and the teams to produce How to vote cards.

Data harvesting by the major parties with respect to postal voting needs to be stopped. As the major parties have access to the Electoral Roll they can mail each voter, offering the option to apply for a postal vote. This information then goes back to the Party. This is not possible for an [redacted] It should be mandatory that the information in requesting a postal vote should be sent directly to the AEC and not be allowed to be directed back to the [redacted] or [redacted] party.

Suggestions;

Dedicated parking bays with sufficient signage so that voters know they can vote in their car if they are unable to enter the booth.

Adequate numbers of AEC staff to monitor both the lines and these disabled/ vote in car accessible bays at busy booths

Penalties for data harvesting under the guise of postal vote application

Streamlining of the nomination and ballot process to allow earlier publication and availability of postal votes.

Involvement of the Christian Brethren as paid volunteers in Forrest

I attended the prepolling station at Busselton Baptist church, Recreation Lane, Busselton on Tuesday April 22 and was immediately surprised to find a large number (approximately 8) of young men wearing [redacted] Party Tshirts and actively handing out how to vote cards. They were loudly proclaiming [redacted] party slogans as well as actively campaigning against me as [redacted] Candidate. I engaged several of them in conversation over the course of the day to discover that they were all from either Albany or Gnowangerup, they had all been bussed in en masse and they were being accommodated around Busselton for the duration of the polling period. They had no relationship to the [redacted]

Party that could be ascertained during multiple conversations. There appeared to be a number of family groups amongst them which included some female partners and children and older middle aged men. Over the day these other members joined in with the campaigning.

I was again present at the prepoll centre on 24 April in Busselton and although the group of young men had largely moved on there were still a number of volunteers who were clearly not associated with the [redacted] Party but who were clearly campaigning for them on this day. Once again, they were all from either Albany or Gnowangerup and often seemed to be from the same family groups. They women were all dressed in the manner of the Christian Brethren church.

I then attended the prepolling station in Eagle Bay on Monday 28/4/25 and once again was surprised to see a group of middle aged men loudly campaigning for the [redacted] Party. Once again I engaged in conversation with them and it became apparent that they were not from our Electorate and had been brought in as volunteers. One of the men then isolated me from the rest of my volunteers and started preaching to me about God and the afterlife and interrogating me about my religious beliefs. He continued to preach at me for around about 10 minutes and made me feel very uncomfortable given that I was meant to be there in my campaign candidate role. I felt extremely concerned by this behaviour and noted a volunteer from another Party looking very upset. I heard afterwards that the same [redacted] party “volunteers” who had approached me to discuss religion had verbally abused her about her party’s position on Gay and trans rights.

Around this time there was widespread reporting of supposed [redacted] Party volunteers, who in fact were members of the Christian Brethren Church, from around the country, and I could see stark similarities between what was being reported in the Eastern States and what was happening on the ground in prepolling in Forrest.

I was at the Australind prepolling site on Tuesday 29/4/25,and once again there was a contingent of men loudly voicing slogans for the [redacted] Party and directly attacking me as [redacted] Candidate. By this time, they had become less willing to engage in polite conversation

and would not admit to being from outside the Electorate. It was however clear when they were asked questions which would require local knowledge that they were not locals.

I understand that many of these volunteers were paid for their time which then should be identifiable as income for the charity and, if they were not paid, their campaign activities should be declared as an in-kind donation to the [redacted] Party to the AEC.

Suggestion

I would like to request an investigation into the political activities of the Christian Brethren around the time of the Federal Election and any irregularities into monies received over this time also explored. I believe their activities were in breach of the ACNC rules around actions of charitable institutions and hope that if this is found to be true that they will lose their charitable status

Final comments

We desperately need updated advertising laws to cover political campaigns

We absolutely need more transparency of affiliate groups like Keep the Sheep , Teals revealed and The Christian Brethren.

Moderation of social media is overdue and absolutely necessary.

Without significant reform our fundamental relationships to our democratic systems will be undermined with each election cycle.

Yours sincerely

[redacted]

[redacted]